



TokyoExpat

YOUR JAPAN RELOCATION EXPERTS

2026 EDITION

Japan Relocation Checklist

Everything you need to do before, during, and after your move to Japan — from visa to bank account.

6

MONTHS BEFORE

90+

ACTION ITEMS

7

PHASES

0

ADMIN SURPRISES



PHASE 1

6 to 3 Months Before Arrival

**Determine your visa type ★**

Working Holiday, HSP, Spouse, Student, or Business Manager

**Start visa application ★**

Gather documents: bank statements, employment letter, CV

**Research neighborhoods**

Shinjuku, Shibuya, Setagaya, Koto, Adachi by budget/lifestyle

**Set your housing budget**

Tokyo average: 80,000-130,000 JPY/month for 1K/1LDK

**Book temporary accommodation**

Monthly apartment or guesthouse for first 1-2 months

**Notify your home country bank**

International transfers, notify of address change

**Open a Wise account**

Best rates for JPY transfers, essential for expats

**Sort out health insurance**

SafetyWing for transit period before National Health Insurance

**Decide what to ship vs. sell**

Japan has strict customs rules. Electronics/furniture often not worth shipping

**Get International Driving Permit**

Valid for 1 year in Japan. Required if you plan to drive



PHASE 2

1 to 2 Months Before Arrival

**Book your flights ★**

One-way or round-trip depending on visa requirements

**Arrange document apostilles**

Birth certificate, marriage certificate if applicable

**Research Japanese language basics**

Hiragana, katakana, key phrases for daily life

**Set up mail forwarding**

Notify all important services of your future absence

**Cancel or transfer subscriptions**

Gym, streaming services, insurance policies

**Scan all important documents**

Passport, diploma, birth certificate, store in cloud

**Research SIM card options**

Sakura Mobile, IIJmio, LINEMO — buy at airport or online

**Download essential apps**

Google Maps, Google Translate, Hyperdia, Suica, LINE

Pro tip — Carry-on essentials

Pack your passport, all visa documents, temporary accommodation address, and 100,000 JPY cash in your carry-on. Japanese customs may ask for your address in Japan.



PHASE 3

First 48 Hours in Japan

**Register your address at the Ward Office (Shiyakusho) ★**

Bring passport + visa. You receive your Residence Card (Zairyu Card). Mandatory within 14 days but do it immediately.

**Get a SIM card ★**

Sakura Mobile and IJmio are foreigner-friendly. Airport counters available at Narita and Haneda.

**Get a Suica card (IC card)**

At any JR station or 7-Eleven ATM. Load 3,000-5,000 JPY. Works on trains, buses, convenience stores.

**Locate nearest convenience store, supermarket, and pharmacy**

7-Eleven and FamilyMart ATMs accept foreign cards. Matsumoto Kiyoshi for pharmacy.

**Check in to temporary accommodation**

Confirm check-in time in advance. Japanese guesthouses often have strict rules.

Important: Residence Card comes first

Without your Residence Card address, you cannot open a bank account, sign a lease, or register for National Health Insurance. Do this on Day 1.



PHASE 4

First 2 Weeks

**Open a Japanese bank account ★**

PayPay Bank or Sony Bank: 100% online, English UI, foreigner-friendly

**Start apartment search ★**

Use foreigner-friendly agencies: Sakura House, Oakhouse, bilingual agents

**Apply for National Health Insurance**

At your ward office. Required for all residents. ~5,000-20,000 JPY/month

**Apply for National Pension (Kokumin Nenkin)**

At ward office. Low income: apply for exemption (menjo)

**Set up PayPay or LINE Pay**

Cashless payment: essential for taxis, convenience stores, restaurants

**Explore your neighborhood on foot**

Find the closest station, post office, ward office, hospital



PHASE 5

First Month: Settle In

- ☐ **Sign your apartment lease ★**
Budget: 2-3 months deposit + agency fee. Key money (reikin) in some areas.
- ☐ **Set up electricity**
TEPCO in Tokyo: online signup, English available. Done in 1 day.
- ☐ **Set up gas**
Technician visit required. Tokyo Gas. Must be present (half-day).
- ☐ **Set up internet**
NURO Fiber or SoftBank Air. 2-4 week install delay is common.
- ☐ **Register new address at ward office**
Update your Residence Card address within 14 days of moving in.
- ☐ **Apply for My Number Card**
At ward office. Takes 3-6 weeks. Required for taxes, some banking.
- ☐ **Get a personal hanko (seal)**
Optional but useful. Convenience stores have machines (Shachihata).
- ☐ **Visit a local clinic for health check**
Register with a family doctor (かかりつけ医) near your home.



PHASE 6

First 3 Months: Administration

- ☐ **Collect My Number Card**
Bring notification letter + ID to ward office.
- ☐ **Convert driving license (if applicable)**
At JAF center. Bring JP license translation + original. 3-6 months wait.
- ☐ **Register for e-Tax (online tax portal)**
Required for annual tax return in March. maff.go.jp portal.
- ☐ **Update bank account with My Number**
Required by law. Do it at your branch or app.



PHASE 7

Ongoing: Stay Compliant

- ☐ **File annual tax return (kakutei shinkoku)**
Due by March 15. Required if income exceeds 2M JPY/year or multiple sources.
- ☐ **Renew Residence Card before expiry**
Check expiry date. Apply 3 months before at Immigration Services Agency.
- ☐ **Update address after any move**
Within 14 days at ward office. Also update bank, NHI, pension.
- ☐ **Review your visa renewal timeline**
Many visas: 1-3 year terms. Plan renewals 6 months in advance.

TokyoExpat

Your relocation guide for life in Japan

Need personalized advice?

Every relocation is different. Book a 1-on-1 consultation to get answers tailored to your visa situation, timeline, and budget.



1h Consultation

Visa, housing, admin —
answered for your situation



Step-by-step PDF guides for
every stage of your move
PDF Guides



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